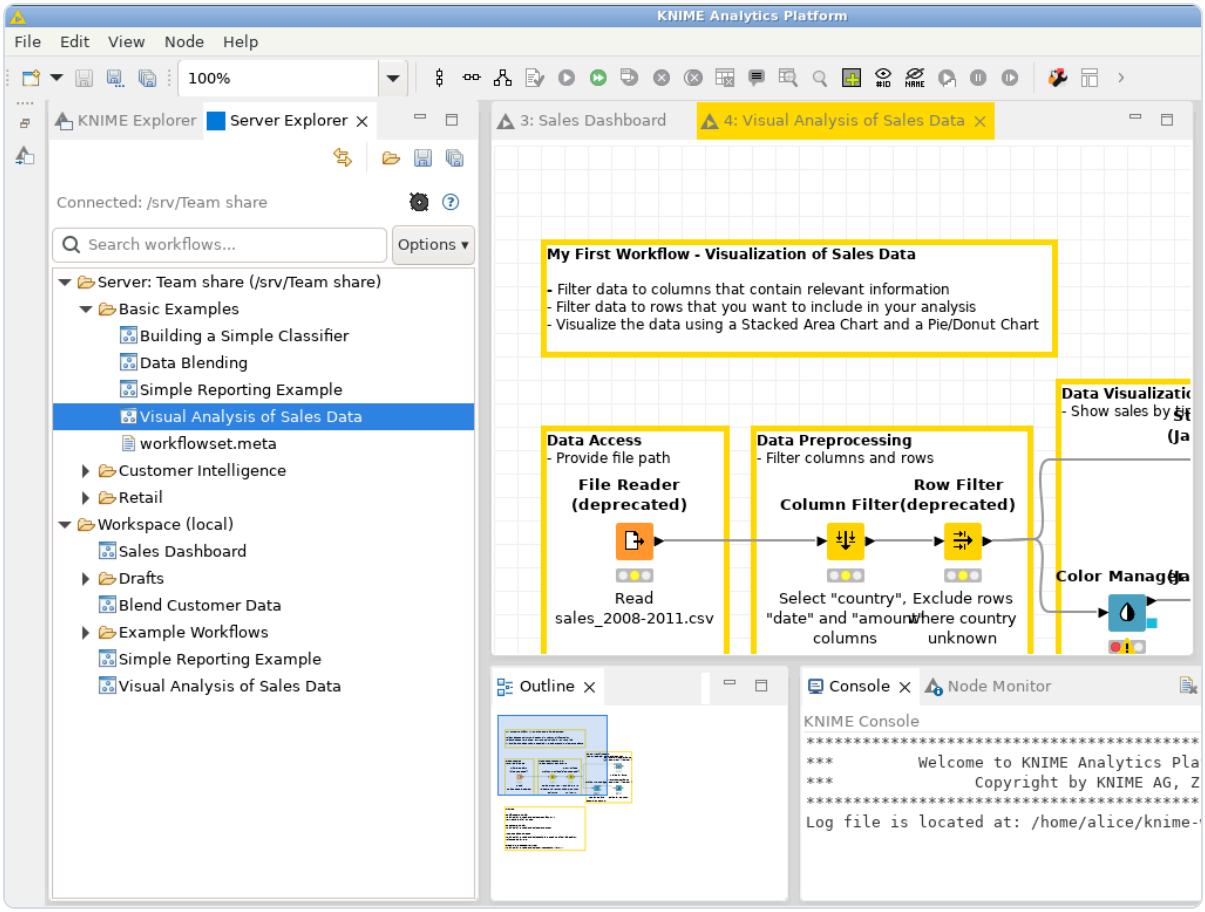
OVF Server Explorer User Guide

Version 1.0.7, for KNIME 4.1 and later, and KNIME 5 in the classic user interface. Server Explorer is a third-party plugin, not a KNIME product. To install or update it, see the install guide.



Server Explorer, top left, with a shared folder above and your own workspace below.

Server Explorer lets a team keep KNIME workflows in one shared place. The tab shows two lists, one above the other:

- **Server**: the shared place. This is either a **workflow server** that your organization runs, reached by a web address, or a **folder**, such as a shared network drive.
- **Workspace (local)**: your own KNIME workspace, the same workflows that KNIME Explorer lists under LOCAL.

To share a workflow, drag it from your workspace up to the server. To use someone else's, drag it down, or just double-click it.

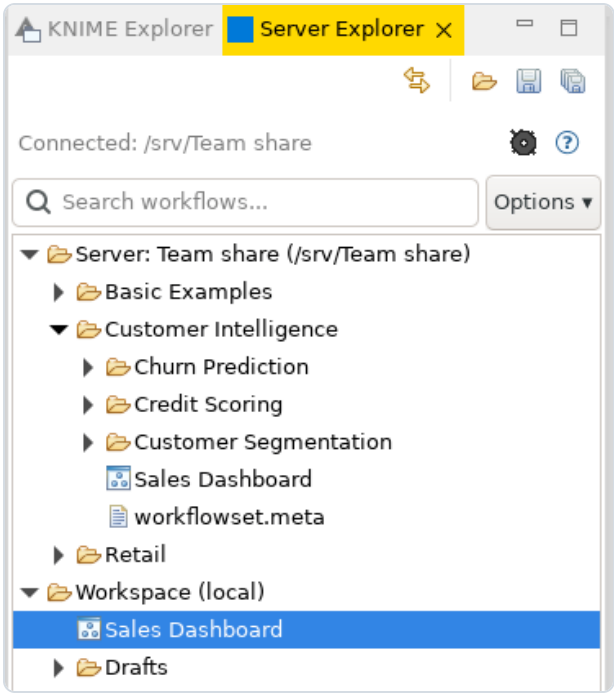
1. Find the tab

Server Explorer is a tab next to **KNIME Explorer**, at the top left of the KNIME window. Click it to bring it to the front.

- **KNIME 5:** the tab is only in the classic user interface. If KNIME opens in the Modern UI, click **Menu › Switch to classic user interface**.
- **Closed it by mistake?** Choose **View › Server Explorer**, or **View › Other... › KNIME Views › Server Explorer**. The tab then stays.

2. What's in the tab

Part	What it does
Buttons, top row	From left: **Refresh**, **New Folder**, **Upload to Server**, **Download to Workspace**.
Status line	Whether the server can be reached. See below.
Gear	Opens the server settings (section 3).
Question mark	Opens this guide.
Search box, **Options**	Narrows the tree to matching names (section 9).
Server: *name* (*address*)	The shared workflows.
Workspace (local)	Your own workflows.

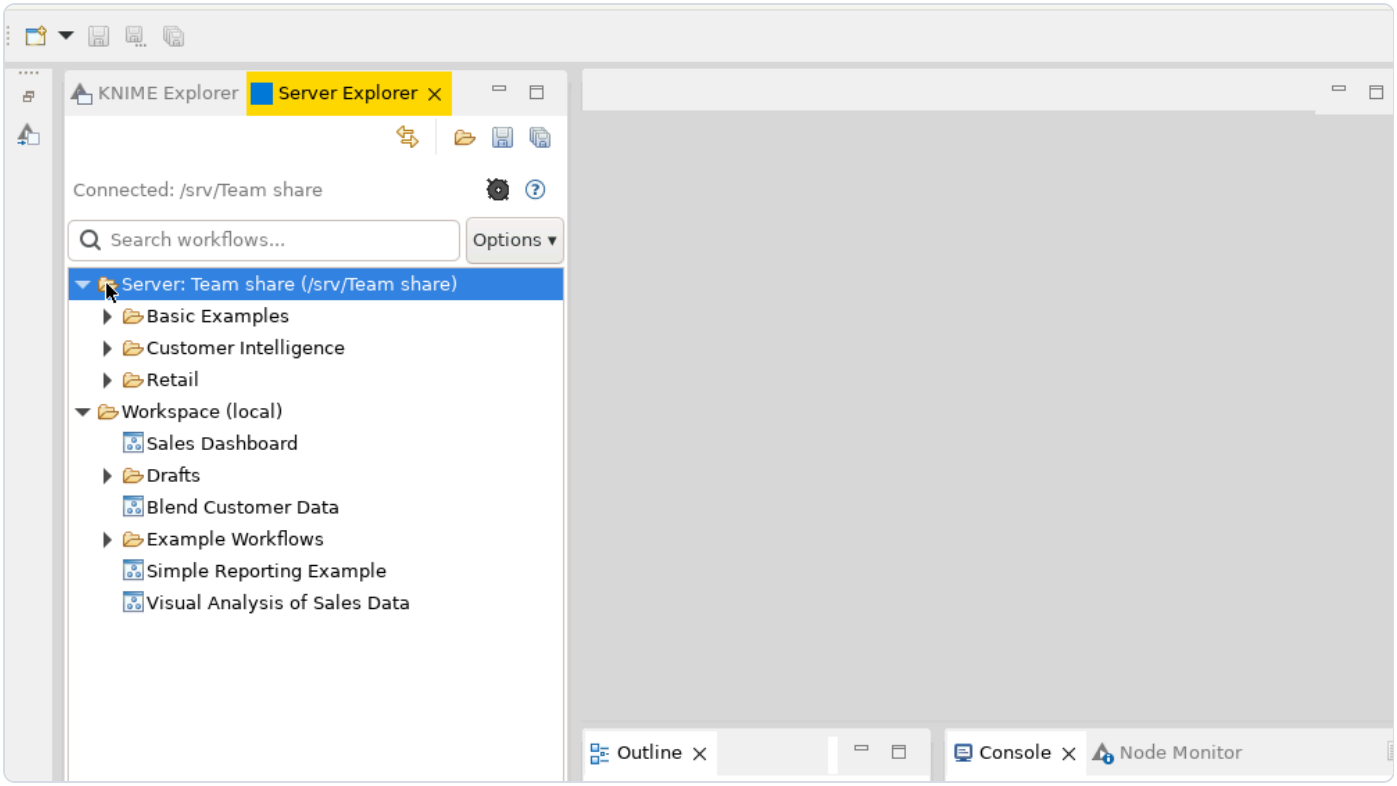


In the tree, a folder icon is a folder, the small diagram icon is a workflow, and a page icon is any other file. Right-click anything for its menu. Double-clicking a folder opens or closes it.

Status line	Meaning

Connected: *address*	All is well.
Offline: *address* (workspace browsing only)	The server can't be reached right now. Your workspace still works. See section 13.
No server configured — click ⚙ to add one	Add a server (section 3).

3. Connect to a server



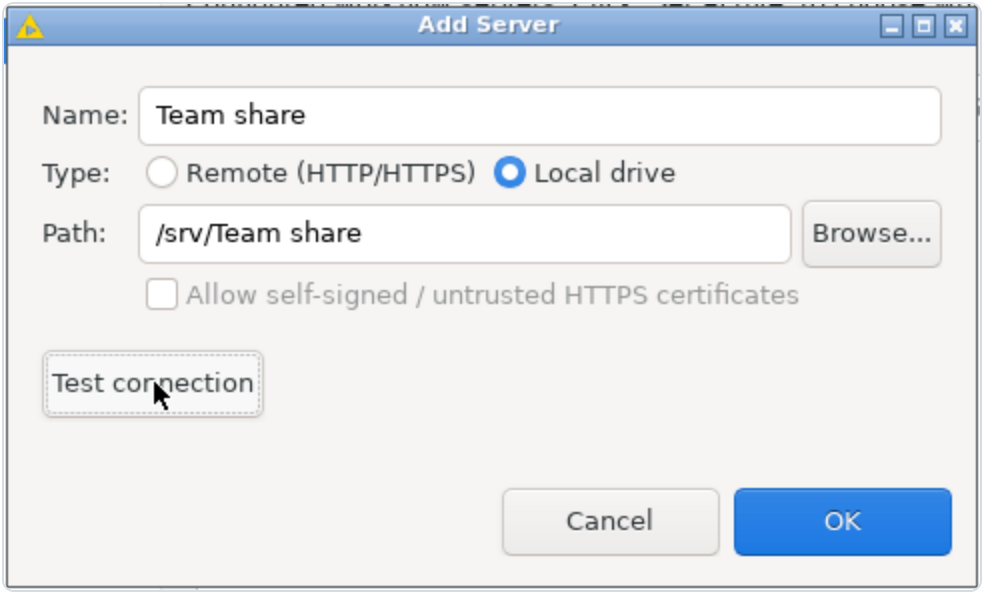
Adding a shared folder as a server.

You need the server's address, or the path to the shared folder. Ask whoever set it up.

1. Click the **gear** in the tab. This opens **Server Connector › Servers** in KNIME's preferences. You can also get there with **File › Preferences**.
2. Click **Add...**
3. Type a **Name** that you'll recognize, such as *Team share*.
4. Choose the **Type**, and fill in the box below it:
    - **Remote (HTTP/HTTPS)** for a workflow server. Enter its address, starting with `https://` or `http://`, for example `https://workflows.example.com`.

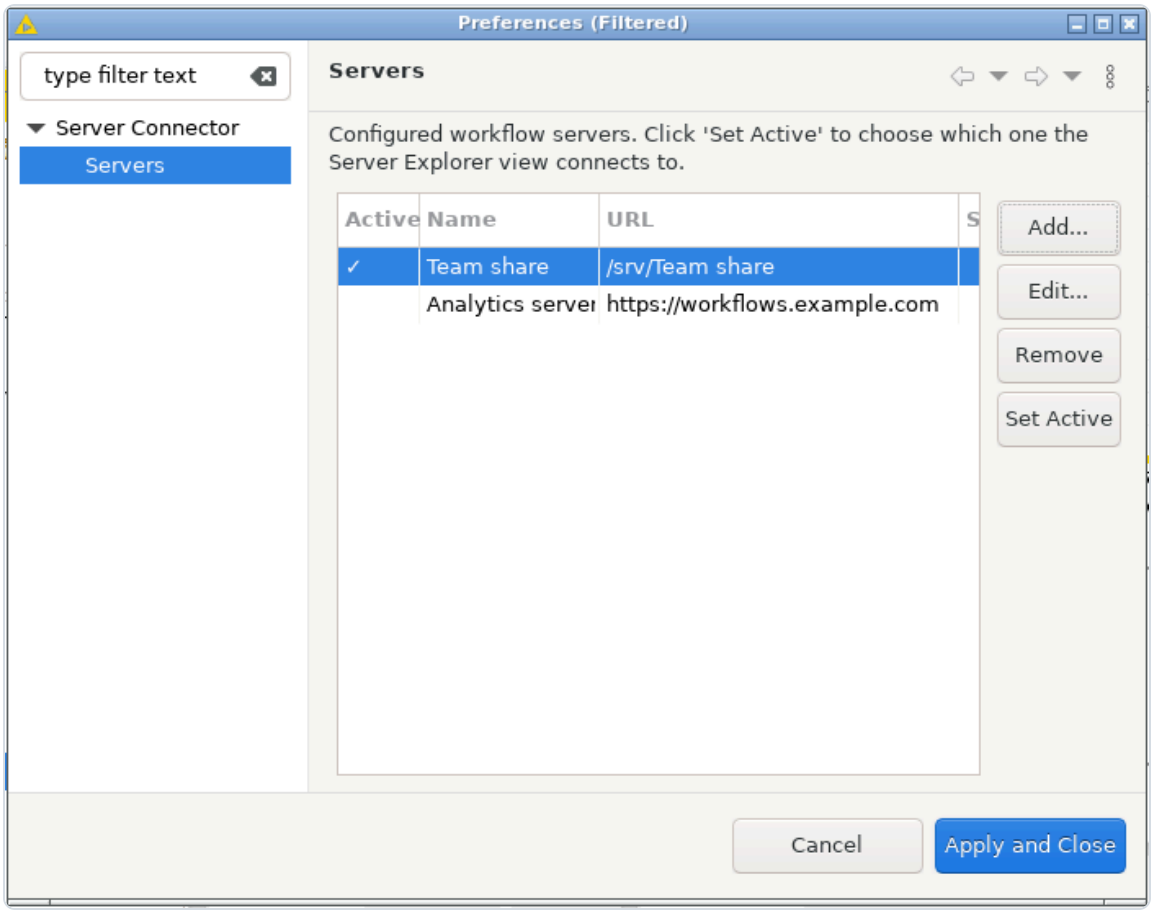
- **Local drive** for a folder. Click **Browse...** or type the path, for example `S:\KNIME workflows`, `\\fileserver\team\knime` or `/mnt/team/knime`. It can be any folder you can open, including a network drive.

5. Click **Test connection**. It should say **Connected successfully**. If not, it suggests a likely cause.
6. Click **OK**, then **Apply and Close**.



Allow self-signed / untrusted HTTPS certificates is only for an `https://` server whose certificate KNIME doesn't trust, which is common for servers inside an organization. Turn it on only if the person who runs the server tells you to, or if Test connection says the certificate couldn't be validated and you know the server is the right one.

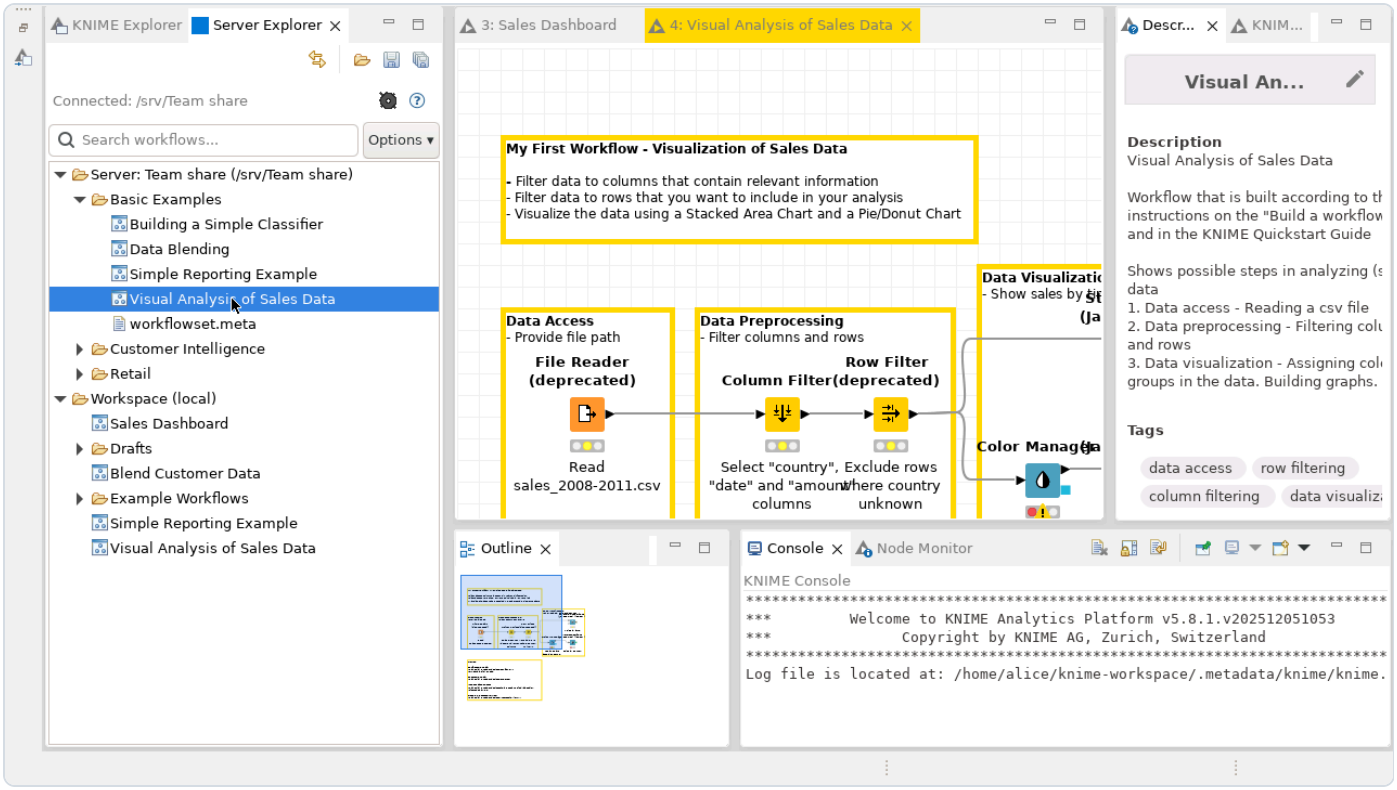
More than one server



The tab shows one server at a time, the one with the tick in the **Active** column. The first server you add becomes active. To switch, select another one, click **Set Active**, then **Apply and Close**. **Edit...** and **Remove** change the list. Nothing changes until you click **Apply and Close**.

> **The server list belongs to the workspace.** If you start KNIME with a different workspace, its list starts empty, so add your servers there too.

4. Open a workflow



Double-clicking a server workflow copies it into your workspace and opens it.

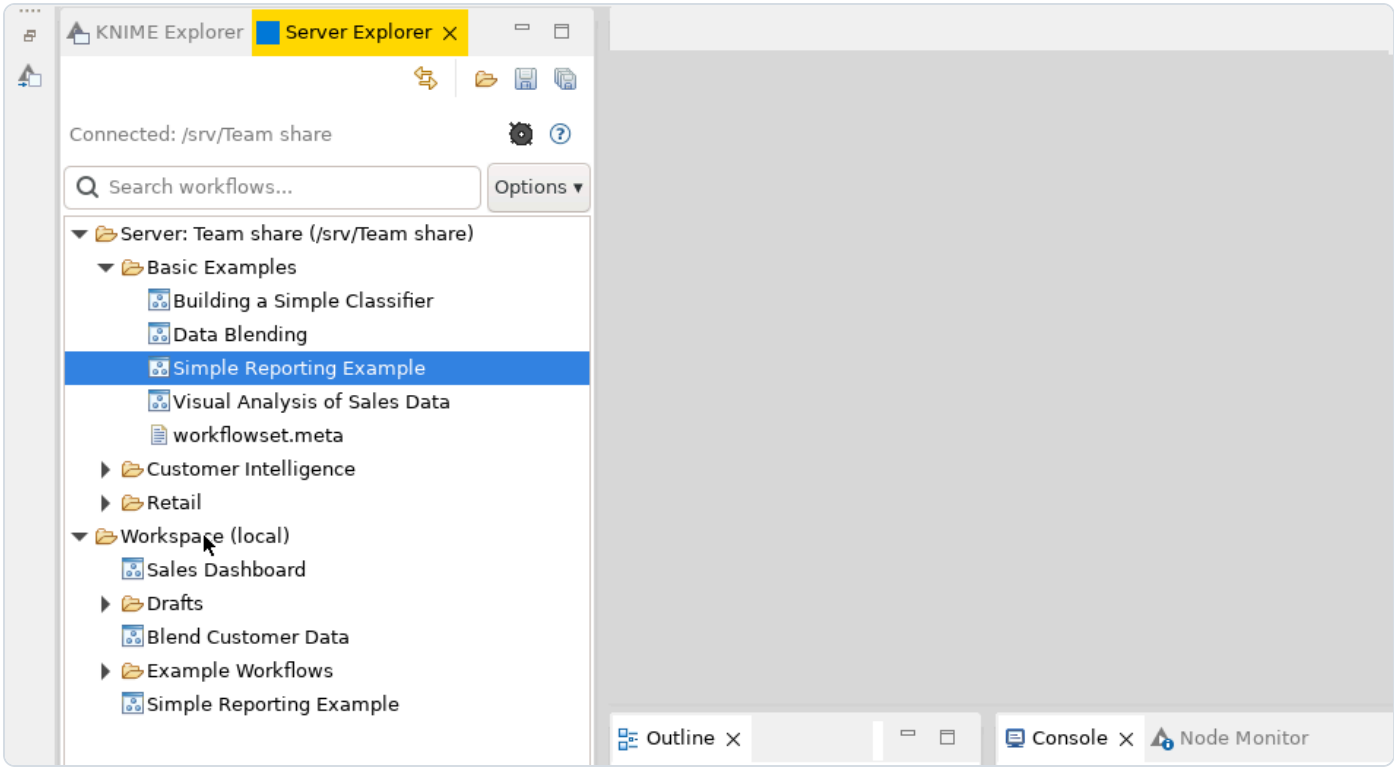
Double-click a workflow, or right-click it and choose **Open Workflow**.

- **In your workspace**, it opens just as it would from KNIME Explorer.
- **On the server**, it's first copied to the top level of your workspace, under the same name, and that copy opens. Your changes go to that copy, not to the server. Upload it when you want to share them (section 6).

> **If your workspace already has a workflow with that name at the top level, double-clicking opens your copy and doesn't fetch the server's.** To get the server's current version, download it (section 5), under a new name if you want to keep yours.

If KNIME reports errors while loading, the workflow probably uses nodes from an extension you don't have. That message comes from KNIME, not from Server Explorer.

5. Download to your workspace



Dragging a workflow from the server onto your workspace.

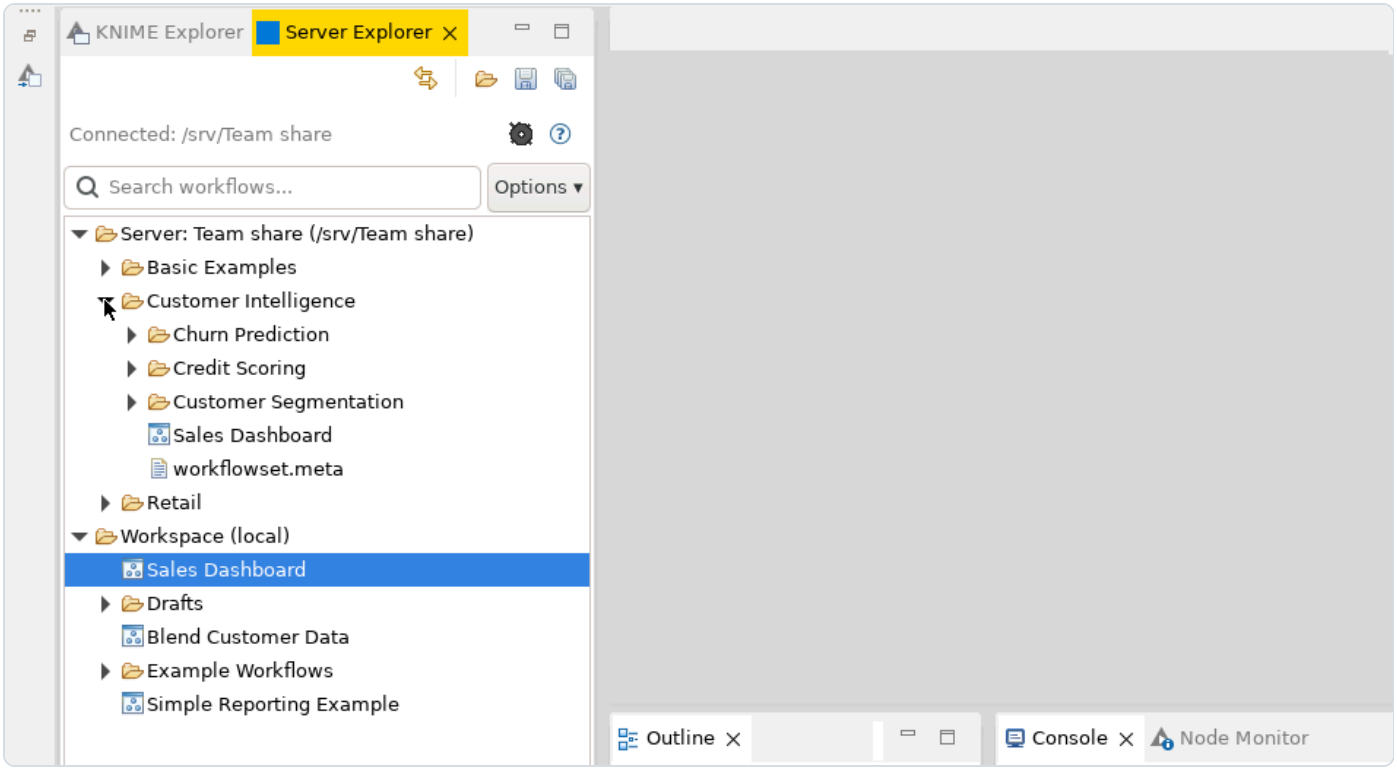
There are two ways:

- **Drag** a workflow or folder from the Server branch and drop it anywhere on the Workspace branch. It keeps its name. You can select several items with Ctrl or Shift and drag them together.
- **Right-click › Download to Workspace**, or select it and click the button at the top. This asks for a name first, so you can keep it apart from a copy you already have.

Downloads always go to the **top level** of your workspace, even if you drop onto a folder there. To put one in a folder, drag it there afterwards. A folder comes with everything inside it. KNIME Explorer shows the download too.

> **A download replaces a workflow of the same name without asking.** Its files are overwritten with the server's, so changes you made to your copy are lost. Use **Right-click › Download to Workspace** and a new name to keep both.

6. Upload to the server



Dragging a workflow from your workspace into a folder on the server.

- **Drag** a workflow or folder from the Workspace branch onto a folder on the server. Dropping on a workflow puts it in that workflow's folder, and dropping on the **Server:** line puts it at the top level.
- **Right-click › Upload to Server**, or the button at the top, asks for a name and puts it at the **top level** of the server.

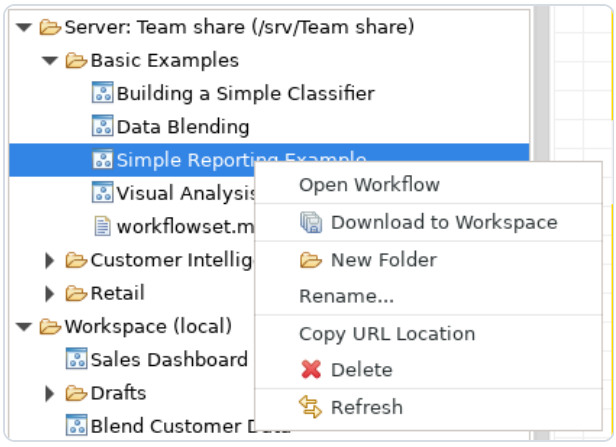
> **Save first.** An upload copies the workflow as it is saved on disk, so changes you haven't saved aren't included.

> **An upload replaces anything on the server with the same name, in the same folder, without asking.** Everyone then gets your version. If a colleague may have changed it, download theirs first, under a new name, and compare.

Uploads and downloads run in the background, with a progress window you can cancel. A message says when each one is done. To stop seeing these messages, tick **Don't show this again**.

7. Folders, renaming, moving and deleting

These work the same way on both branches. Right-click an item to see them.



- **New Folder** creates a folder in the selected folder, or next to the selected workflow.
- **Rename...**, or F2. Names can't contain `/` or `\`.
- **Move:** drag an item onto a folder in the same branch. In your workspace, the move stops if the folder already has something with that name.
- **Delete** asks first. You can select several items and delete them at once.

> **Delete is permanent.** Nothing goes to the Recycle Bin or Trash. Deleting from the server removes it for everyone.

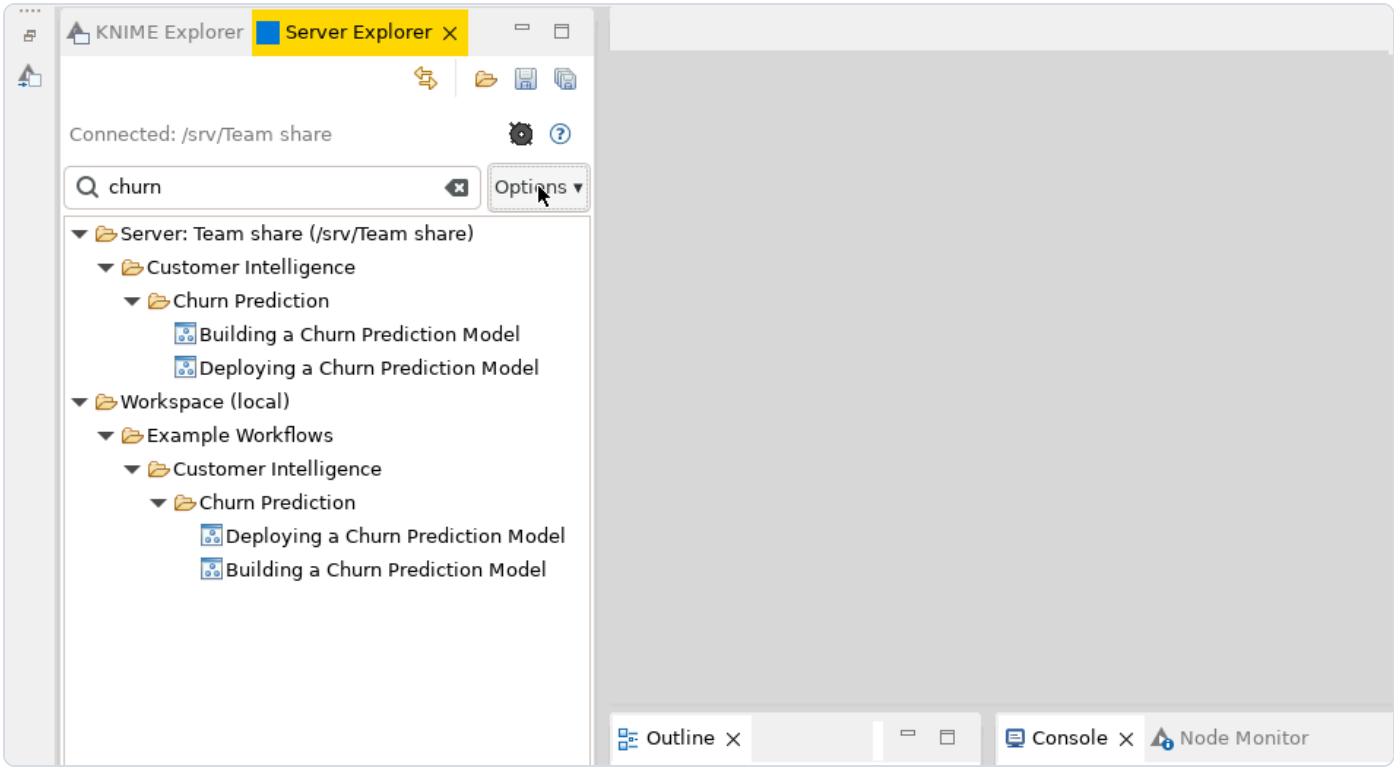
Close a workflow in KNIME before renaming, moving or deleting it.

8. Copy a workflow's address

Right-click › Copy URL Location puts the item's address on the clipboard, ready to paste. Select several to get one address per line.

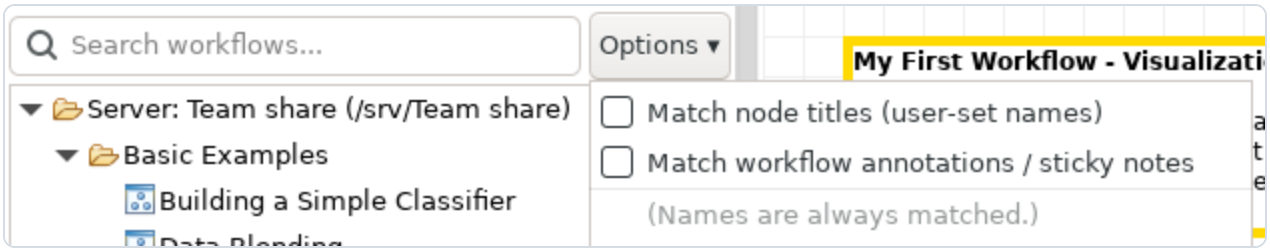
Item	Address
In your workspace	`knime://LOCAL/Folder/Workflow`. KNIME's reader and writer nodes accept this.
On a Local drive server	A `file:` address of the folder
On a Remote server	The server's download address for it

9. Search



Typing in the search box narrows both branches.

Type in **Search workflows...** and both branches narrow to the items whose names contain what you typed, with the folders they're in opened. Capitals don't matter. Click the **×** in the box to clear it, and the tree goes back to how it was.

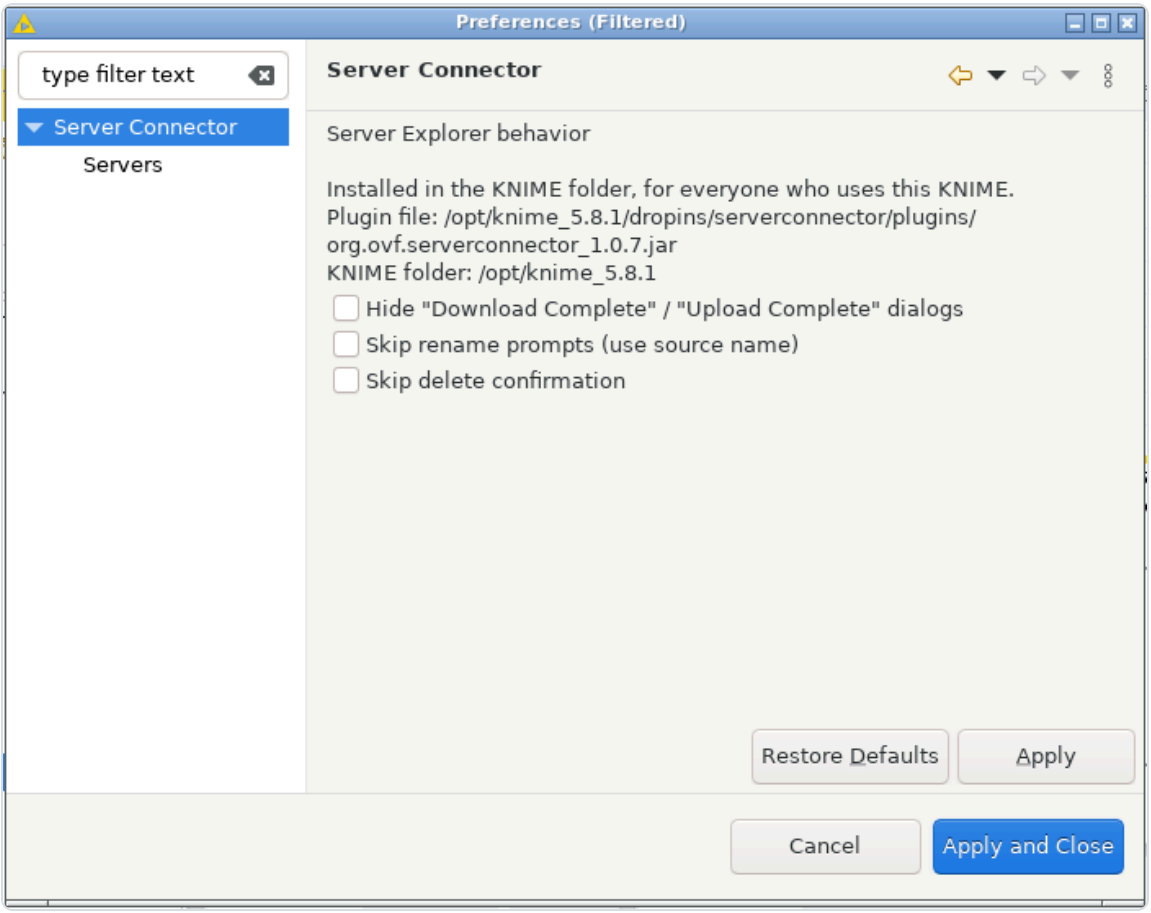


Options can also look inside workflows, at the names you've given nodes and at the notes on the canvas. These searches read every workflow, so results take longer, especially on a big server.

10. Seeing other people's changes

The Server branch checks for changes by itself: every 10 seconds while the tab is in use, and every minute otherwise. Your workspace updates when you come back to the tab, and when items are added or removed at its top level. To update straight away, click **Refresh**. A refresh closes the server's folders.

11. Settings

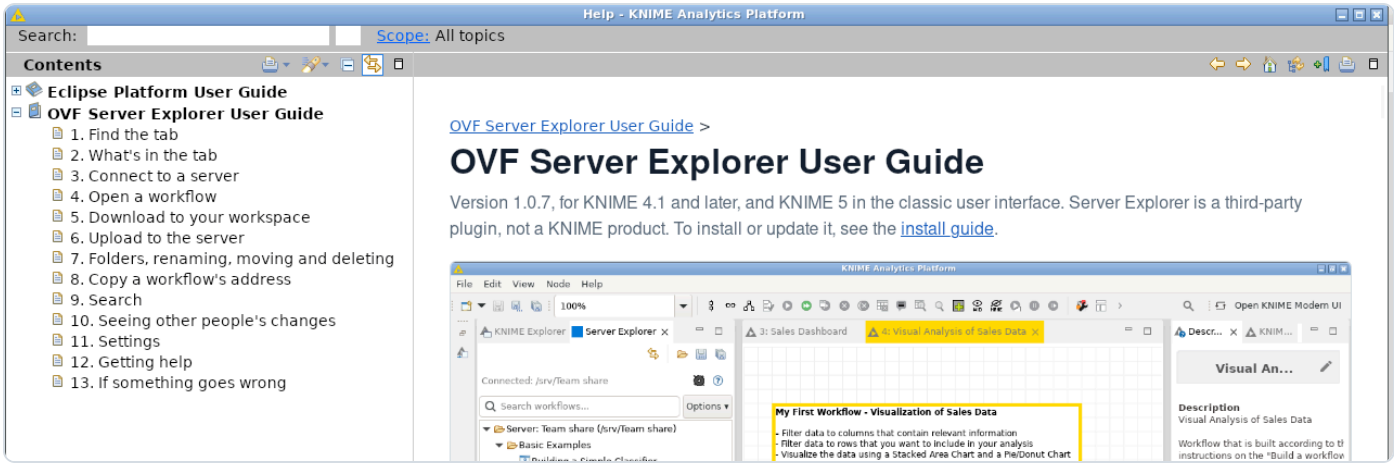


File › Preferences › Server Connector:

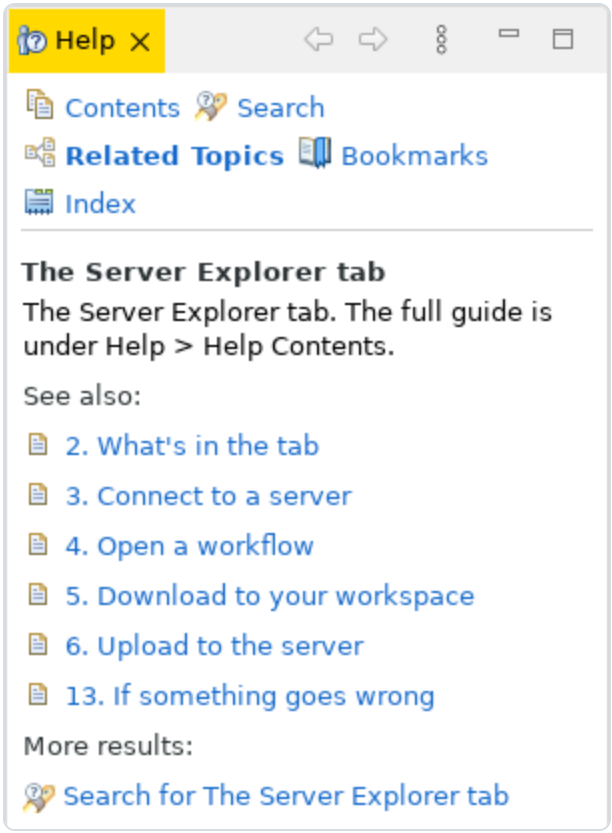
- **Hide "Download Complete" / "Upload Complete" dialogs.**
- **Skip rename prompts (use source name).** The buttons and menu items then upload and download straight away, under the item's own name.
- **Skip delete confirmation.** Deleting then happens with one click, and can't be undone.

The page also says who has the plugin and which file it was loaded from, which helps when asking for support. These settings, like the server list, belong to the workspace.

12. Getting help



- The **question mark** in the tab opens this guide in KNIME's help window.
- **Help › Help Contents** lists it as **OVF Server Explorer User Guide**.
- In the tab or on the plugin's settings pages, press F1 on Windows, or Ctrl+F1 on Linux. KNIME's Help panel opens with links to the sections about what you're looking at.



- Online: this guide (PDF) and the install guide.

13. If something goes wrong

What you see	What to do

Offline: *address*	Check your network or VPN. On the Servers page, select the server, click **Edit...** and **Test connection**: it usually says why.
Test connection: *not speaking TLS on that port*	Try the address with `http://` instead of `https://`.
Test connection: *TLS certificate could not be validated*	See the note on self-signed certificates in section 3.
Test connection: *nothing is listening*, *could not be resolved* or *timed out*	The address is wrong, the server is down, or a firewall or VPN is in the way. Check the address with whoever runs the server.
A line starting **Error:** under the server	The server or folder couldn't be read. For a Local drive, check that you can open the folder outside KNIME.
is not a workflow (no workflow.knime found)	That item is a folder, not a workflow.
Could not open workflow	Open it from KNIME Explorer instead.
The server list is empty	You're probably in a different workspace. Add the servers again (section 3).
A drag does nothing	Drags work within this tab only, not to or from KNIME Explorer. All dragged items must come from the same branch, and an item can't be dropped onto itself.
No Server Explorer tab	See section 1. If it's not under **View** either, the plugin isn't installed in this KNIME: see the install guide.
A red tab, **Server Explorer (needs OVF plugin)**	This KNIME doesn't have the plugin, but the workspace was used with one that does. Close the tab, or use the KNIME that has the plugin. Nothing is lost.